

Grapple for greatness

Ilia Topuria will face Charles Oliveira for the **newly vacant** lightweight title in the main event of UFC 317.

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With Dustin Poirier's retirement fight confirmed as the main event of UFC 318 early last month, the promotion's CEO, Dana White, announced two more numbered events. First, UFC 317 will be part of the annual International Fight Week — a week-long event that includes the Hall of Fame induction ceremony. The main event for this blockbuster card will be a clash for the newly vacant lightweight title.

With Islam Makhachev making a strategic move up to the welterweight division, the 155-pound throne is now open for two of the division's most electrifying talents to contest. Charles 'Do Bronx' Oliveira, the Brazilian submission ace and former

champion, is set to take on the surging Ilia 'El Matador' Topuria (**above, left**), who, with his devastating striking power, had been tearing through the featherweight ranks. His move up to lightweight for a title shot is a bold statement of intent. This match-up promises a classic grappler-vs-striker dynamic, with the coveted gold on the line.

The fight card is further bolstered by another exciting title bout. Flyweight champion Alexandre 'The Cannibal' Pantoja will defend his belt against the hard-hitting Kai 'Don't Blink' Kara-France. Pantoja, riding an impressive seven-fight winning streak and fresh off three successful title defences, will be looking to solidify his reign. Kara-France, meanwhile, after a quick TKO victory in his last outing, is eager for his second shot at undisputed UFC glory.

Meanwhile, middleweight

champion Dricus 'Stillknocks' du Plessis (**above, right**) is set to defend his crown against the undefeated Khamzat 'Borz' Chimaev, in a match that will headline UFC 319 in Chicago on August 18. **Boasting an unblemished professional record, Chimaev has been a force of nature with a 60 per cent finish rate, creating an aura of invincibility.** His most recent triumph — a swift submission victory over former champion Robert Whittaker — cemented his status as a top contender and paved the way for this championship challenge, despite just five fights in the promotion.

Standing across the cage will be the reigning champion, du Plessis. The South African powerhouse captured the title in a hard-fought battle against Sean Strickland and has since defended his belt twice — once against Israel Adesanya and again in a rematch with Strickland. An underdog storyline is always exhilarating, and the middleweight title fight could very well fit the bill should Chimaev do the unthinkable.

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